



SAMPURAN ENGLISH

CONDITIONAL TENSE (Notes)

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Conditional tenses are used to talk about (or guess) what could happen, what might have happened, and what we wish would happen. In English, most conditional sentences contain the word “*if*” to talk about a condition.

- ✓ A conditional sentence has two clauses — an “**if clause**” and a “**main clause**” — which can be dependent on each other.

🔑 Words that show/denote conditions

If, if only, only if, even if, till, until, unless, whether, when, whenever, wherever, since, yet, therefore, because, but for, before, after, once, as long as, as soon as, as a result of, as a consequence of, on the condition that, providing, provided, assuming, etc.

Ex. **If** she comes to the party, I will certainly talk to her.

Ex. **Even if** she doesn't come to the party, I will certainly call her.

Ex. She doesn't talk to me **until** I talk to her first.

Ex. **Unless** you have a ticket, you won't be able to get in the plane.

Ex. **If** I had worked harder, I would have passed the exam.

💡 Remember that -

The order of the clauses in a conditional sentence **does not matter** — the meaning stays the same.

Ex. **If** she comes to the party tonight, I will certainly talk to her. (Correct)

Ex. I will certainly talk to her, **if** she comes to the party tonight. (Correct)

★ Quick Revision: Types of Conditional Sentences

Type	Structure (If-clause + Main clause)	Usage	Example
Zero Conditional	If + Present Simple, + Present Simple	General truths, facts, scientific laws, habits	If you heat ice, it melts.
First Conditional	If + Present Simple, + will/shall + V1	Real / likely future possibility	If it rains, we will cancel the picnic.
Second Conditional	If + Past Simple, + would/could/might + V1	Hypothetical or unreal situation in the present/future	If I were you, I would accept the offer.
Third Conditional	If + Past Perfect, + would/could/might + have + V3	Hypothetical or unreal situation in the past (cannot be changed now)	If she had studied harder, she would have passed.

Key Rules to Remember

1. In the 'If' clause of a First Conditional sentence, never use 'will/shall' — use the Present Simple tense only. (If you will come → If you come)
2. In the 'If' clause of a Second Conditional sentence, use the Past Simple. With the verb 'be', always use 'were' for all subjects (If I were, If he were), not 'was'.
3. In the 'If' clause of a Third Conditional sentence, use the Past Perfect (had + V3), never 'would have'. (If I would have known → If I had known)
4. 'Unless' means 'if...not'. Never use 'unless' together with a negative verb (Unless you don't work hard → Unless you work hard).
5. 'Had' can replace 'If' at the start of a Third Conditional sentence, with subject-auxiliary inversion (Had she informed me = If she had informed me).
6. The main clause of a Zero Conditional sentence never takes 'will'; it takes the Present Simple, since it states a general truth (If water boils, it will evaporate → it evaporates).

0 Zero Conditional Tense (No Condition, 100% Truth)

The “zero conditional” expresses “general truths” — situations in which one thing always causes another. When we use “the zero conditional”, we talk about a “general truth”. Both the “if clause” and the “main clause” remain in the simple present tense.

If Clause (Simple Present Tense)	Main Clause (Simple Present Tense)
If this thing <i>happens</i> ,	Then that thing <i>happens</i> .
If you <i>heat</i> ice,	it <i>melts</i> .
If it <i>rains</i> ,	the grass <i>gets</i> wet.

Examples:

- Ex.** If you touch a fire, you get burned.
- Ex.** People die if they don't eat.
- Ex.** Snakes bite if they are scared.
- Ex.** If babies are hungry, they cry.
- Ex.** You get water if you mix hydrogen and oxygen.

⚠ Common Mistake in Exams

The most common mistake is using the simple future tense in a **zero conditional** — always use simple present in BOTH clauses.

- Ex. If water reaches 100 degrees, it will boil. (Incorrect)
- Ex. If water reaches 100 degrees, it boils. (Correct)
- Ex. If you don't brush your teeth, you will get cavities. (Incorrect)
- Ex. If you don't brush your teeth, you get cavities. (Correct)

1 Type 1 Conditional Tense

The Type 1 conditional refers to the present or future where the situation is real. It describes “a possible condition (if clause)” and “its probable result (main clause)” — the outcome is likely (but not guaranteed) to happen in the future. The “if clause” remains in the simple present, and the “main clause” remains in the simple future tense.

If Clause (Simple Present Tense)	Main Clause (Simple Future Tense)
If this thing <i>happens</i> ,	Then that thing <i>will happen</i> .
If you <i>don't hurry</i> ,	you <i>will miss</i> the train.
If it <i>rains</i> today,	you <i>will get</i> wet.

Examples:

Ex. If Sally *is* late again, the boss *will be* angry.

Ex. If I *have* time, I *will finish* this letter.

Ex. What *will* you *do* if you *miss* the plane?

Ex. If you *drop* that glass, it *will* break.

2 Type 2 Conditional Tense

The Type 2 conditional refers to a time that is “now (current time) or any time” and a situation that is “unreal” — not based on fact. It describes “a hypothetical condition (if clause)” and its “probable result (main clause)”. The “if clause” remains in the simple past tense, and the “main clause” remains in the present conditional tense.

If Clause (Simple Past Tense)	Main Clause: Present Conditional (would/could + V1)
If this thing <i>happened</i> ,	Then that thing <i>would happen</i> .
If you <i>went</i> to bed earlier,	you <i>would not be</i> so tired.
If I <i>spoke</i> Italian,	I <i>would be</i> working in Italy.

Examples:

Ex. If she *fell*, she *would hurt* herself.

Ex. If I *were* the Queen of England, I *would give* everyone a chicken.

Ex. If you really *loved* me, you *would buy* me a diamond ring.

Ex. If I *were* you, I *would give up* smoking.

Ex. If I *knew* where she lived, I *would go* and see her.

3 Type 3 Conditional Tense

The Type 3 conditional refers to a time that is “in the past” and a situation that is “contrary (opposite) to reality”. The facts are the opposite of what is expressed. It describes an “unreal past condition (if clause)” and its “probable past result (main clause)”. The “if clause” remains in the past perfect tense, and the “main clause” remains in the perfect conditional.

If Clause (Past Perfect Tense)	Main Clause: Perfect Conditional (would/could + have + V3)
If this thing <i>had happened</i> ,	Then that thing <i>would have happened</i> .
If you <i>had studied</i> harder,	you <i>would have passed</i> the exam.
If I <i>had accepted</i> that promotion,	I <i>would have been</i> working in Milan.

Examples:

- Ex. If it *had rained*, you *would have gotten* wet.
- Ex. You *would have passed* your exam if you *had worked* harder.
- Ex. I *would have believed* you if you *hadn't lied* to me before.
- Ex. If I *had known* you were coming, I *would have baked* a cake.
- Ex. If I *had had* your number, I *would have called* you.

Ready to test yourself?

Revise this chapter thoroughly and attempt the **Mock Test** of **New** and **Previous Year Questions** based on Conditional Tense on Telegram.

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